

Q What will be my baby's first reactions after being born?

Your baby's first reaction will be to cry—this is a positive sign that he is able to breathe successfully on his own. Sometimes, babies need assistance and can be given oxygen in the delivery room. Some babies splutter slightly and may need help to clear mucus out of the airways. Your baby will be observed in the first minutes after birth to check his responses.

When first holding your baby, you may notice him turning toward your nipple very soon after birth, displaying the strong instinct newborns have to seek out food immediately.

Q Will I need to have stitches if I tear during the delivery?

This depends on the severity of the tear (see p.217). A first-degree, or superficial, tear will usually be left to heal by itself. A second-degree tear can be stitched by your doctor in the delivery room under a local anesthetic while you hold your baby. A third- or fourth-degree tear needs to be repaired in an operating room. If you've had an epidural this can be topped off before surgery, otherwise you will be given either a spinal block or a local anesthetic. Very rarely, general anesthesia is given. Your birth partner and your baby may be able to stay with you while you are being stitched.

The stitches are almost always dissolvable so will disappear on their own, within two weeks or so for superficial stitches, and three months for deeper stitches. There is usually no need for a doctor to check them unless you have concerns.



Did you know...

On average, women lose around 12 lb (5.5 kg) immediately after the birth, as they shed the combined weight of the baby, placenta, and amniotic fluid. However, you will still appear pregnant after your baby is born since your uterus takes time to shrink back down and it takes several days or weeks to lose the excess fluid you carried during pregnancy.



Next to you Holding your baby skin to skin after the birth can help to get breast-feeding started and promote early bonding.

Q I've heard there is some bleeding after birth—how much is usual?

There will be some bleeding right after the delivery of your baby when the placenta comes away from the wall of the uterus, exposing the blood vessels it was connected to. Normal levels of blood loss can be up to about 2 cups (600ml) of blood in the first 24 hours. Once the placenta is delivered, the uterus continues to contract, which helps to close the blood vessels and stem the bleeding. If you have an episiotomy or a tear, that may also cause some bleeding.

Postpartum hemorrhage (PPH) is when you have more bleeding than normal. Heavy bleeding within 24 hours of birth is known as primary PPH, and it affects 5 percent of women. The main reason for primary PPH is that the uterus isn't contracting efficiently, which can lead to heavy blood loss.

You will also get a bloody discharge known as lochia after delivery as the uterine lining renews itself (see p.259).

Q What if the bleeding is so heavy that it doesn't stop?

Unless bleeding is obviously profuse, your doctor will first try to stem the flow. He or she may massage the uterus, and/or give you anticoagulant drugs to encourage your blood to clot, or an injection of synthetic oxytocin (see

p.220). If your placenta is incomplete, or the bleeding has no obvious cause, you will probably be taken into an operating room, where, under general anesthesia, an obstetric surgeon will remove the remainder of the placenta surgically, or investigate why you're still bleeding and treat you as necessary. If you have lost a lot of blood, you may be given a blood transfusion.

Q Will I be able to take a shower shortly after the delivery?

Yes. If all is well, you'll be encouraged to wash.

You may feel a bit wobbly, so have someone with you. Your birth partner and baby can come with you (you can wheel your baby in the hospital crib). After an epidural, you will be given a sponge bath, then once you can walk safely, you can shower or take a bath.

Q I'm anxious about going to the bathroom after the birth. Will this hurt?

Your doctor will want to know that you are urinating before discharging you from the hospital, so you'll need to brave the bathroom.

If you had a tear or episiotomy, urinating may sting; pouring lukewarm water over the area as you urinate can be soothing. To make sure first stools are soft and easy to pass, drink plenty of water and eat lots of fiber over the first few days.